

THE MOVE

Tentative marker + specific interpretation + correction invitation. -> I may be reading this wrong: is the main concern [X], or is it more [Y]? -> Before I assume, do you mean [specific read]? -> Can I check whether this is about [topic], or ?

START HERE

Can I check my read before I respond?

SAY THIS

Everyday openers	"Can I check what you mean before I jump in?"
Two-option checks	"Can I check my read — is it this, that, or neither?"
Workplace / professional	"Before I respond, can I check the concern you want me to address?"
Digital / text	"Tone is hard to read here — are you asking for input, or just flagging this?"
High-pressure / conflict	"I do not want to put words in your mouth. Is the issue the decision, the process, or both?"
Sensitive / emotional	"I want to be careful with this. Is it more hurt, frustration, disappointment, or something else?"

AVOID

- The person has already clearly stated what they mean.
- Immediate safety or emergency action takes priority.
- You are using the check to delay accountability.

REMEMBER

If you would not want someone certain about that read of you, do not be certain about it for them.